

2026 Midterms: Electoral Tsunami, Policy Ripple

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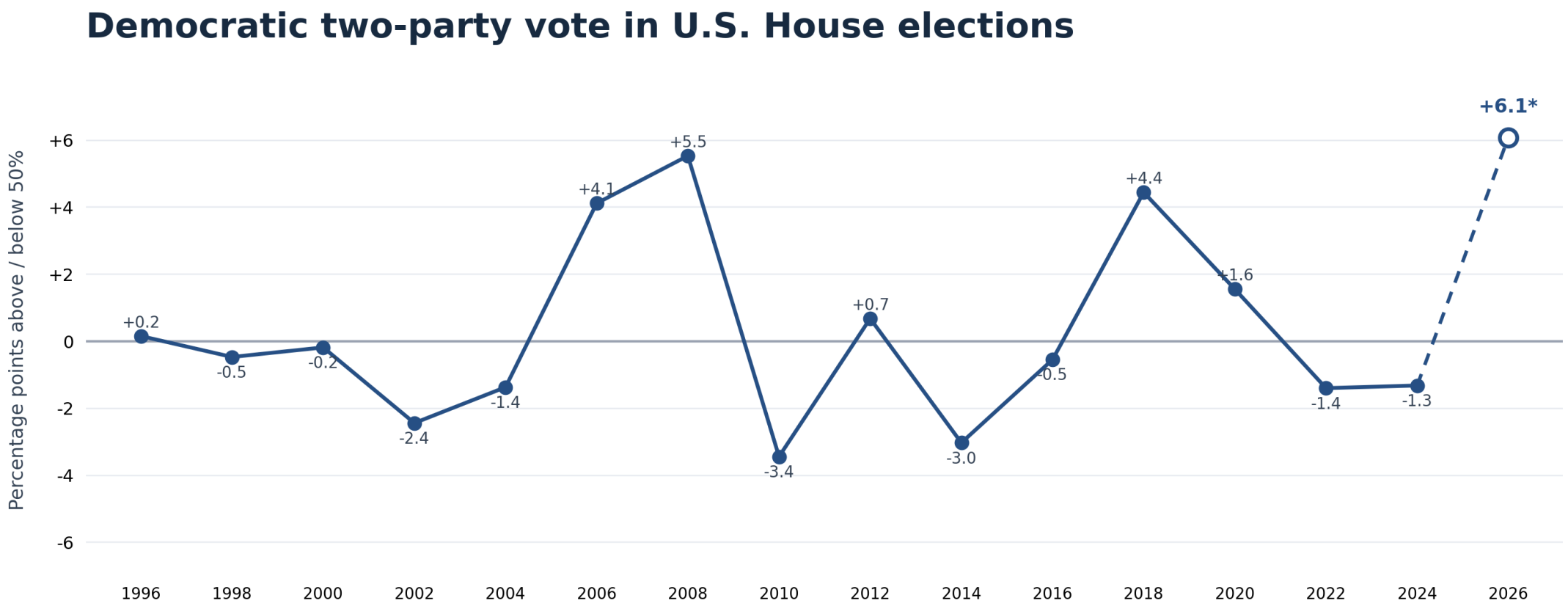
Political Science

What are the consequences of 2026?

3 Graphs:

- How big was the Tsunami?
- Fundamental change or pendulum swing?
- How has the composition of Congress changed?

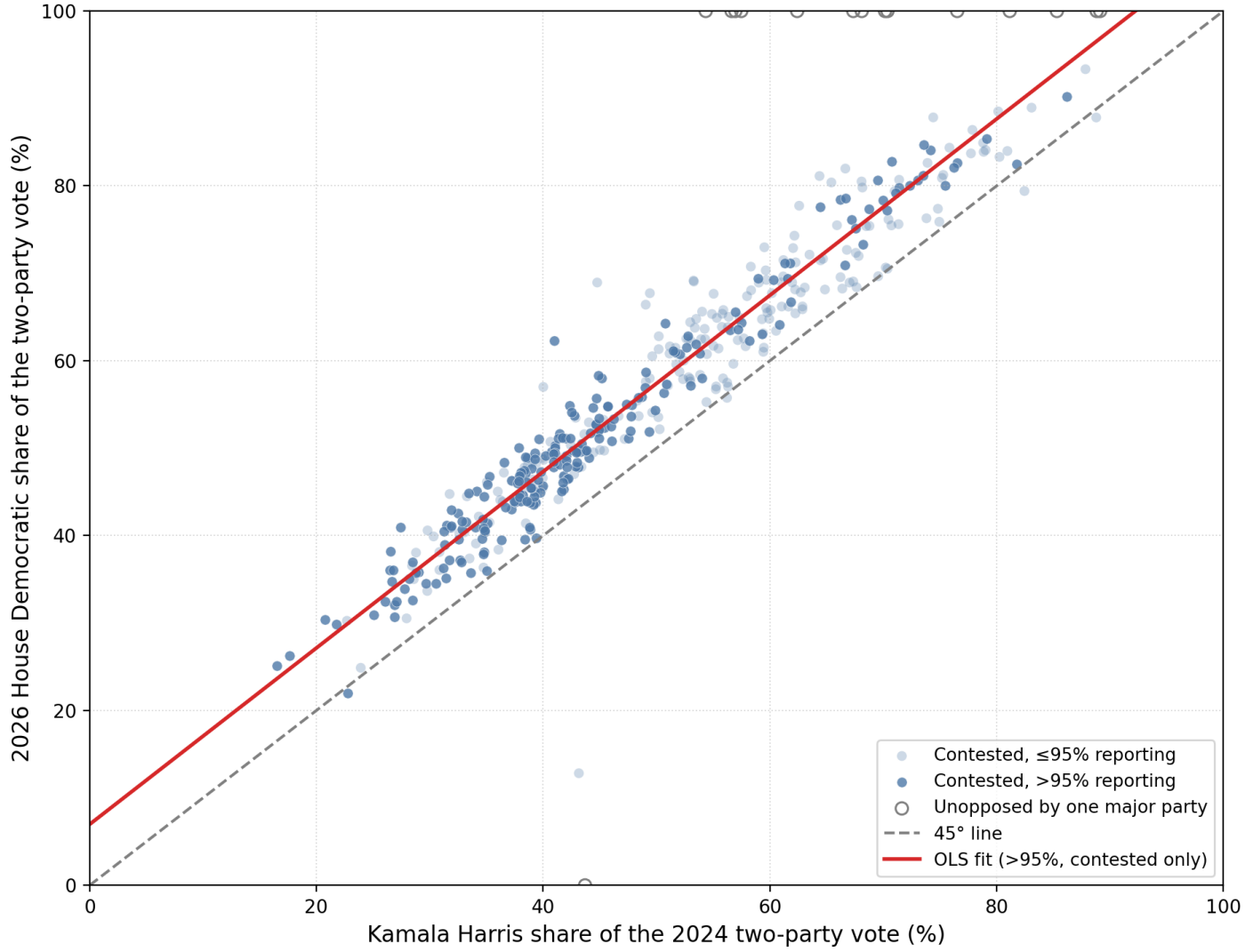
How big of a Tsunami?



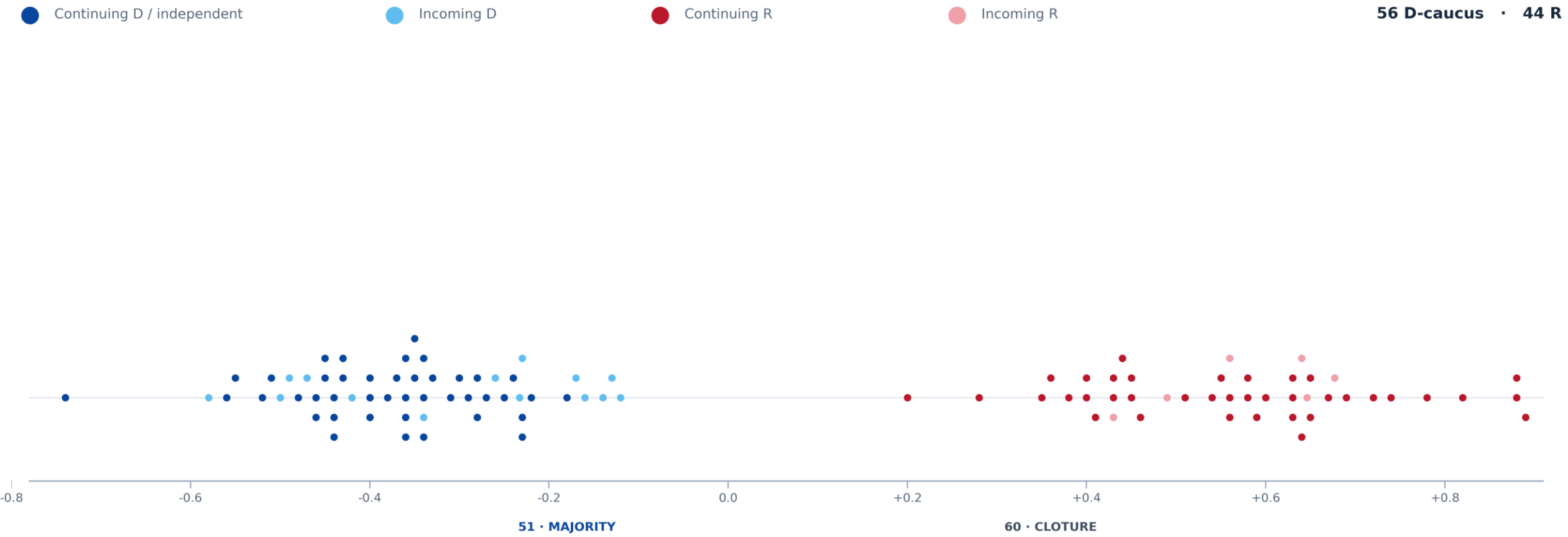
Sources: U.S. House election statistics via Ballotpedia (1996–2024); Elections Archive live vote count (2026).

* 2026 is provisional (Nov. 5, 2026). No imputations for unopposed seats; independent and minor-party votes excluded.

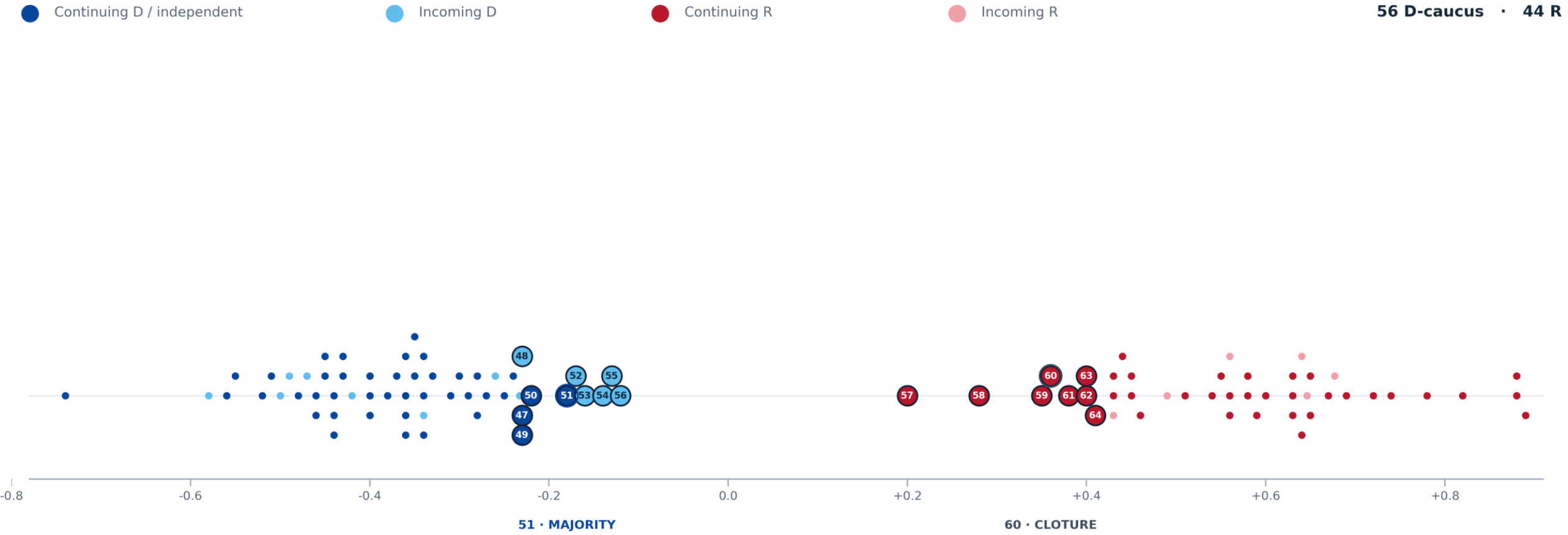
Where did people shift towards the Democrats?



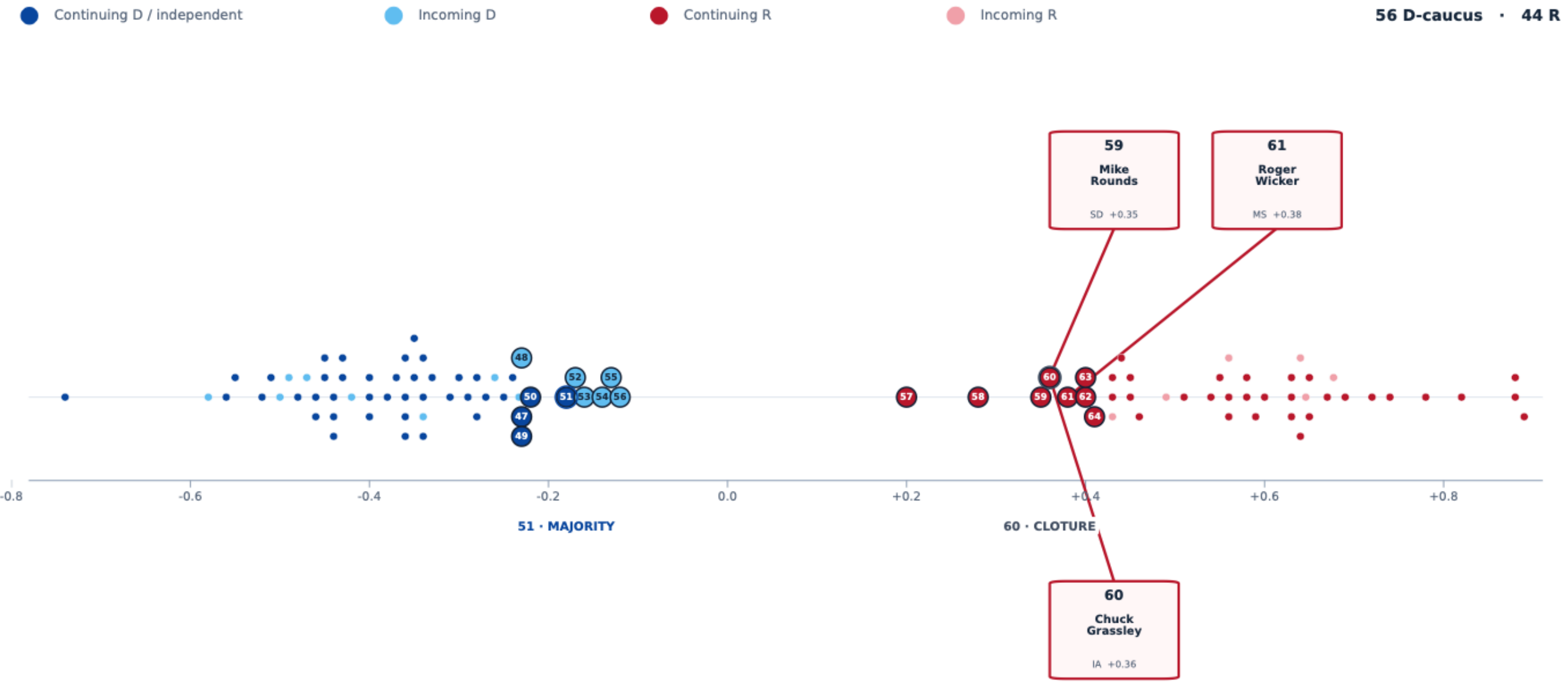
What will the Senate look like?



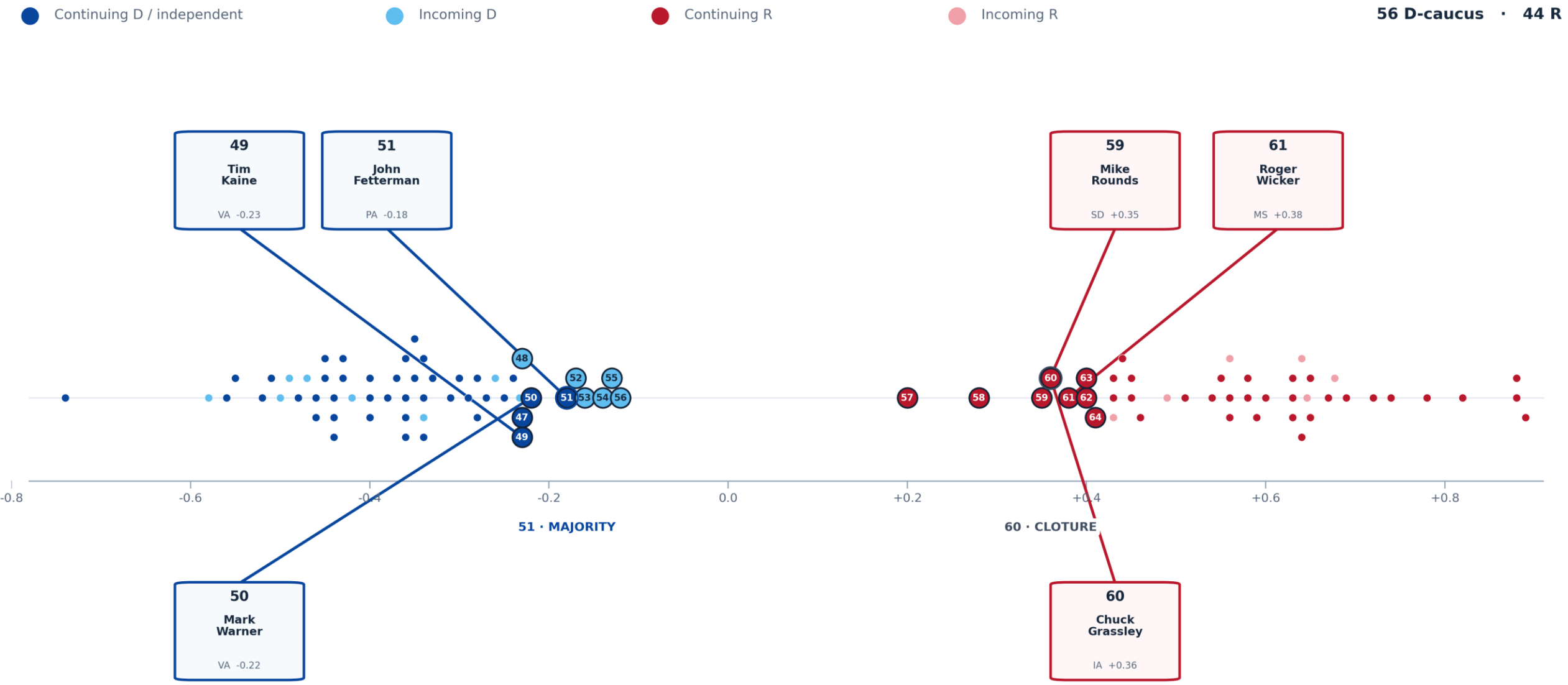
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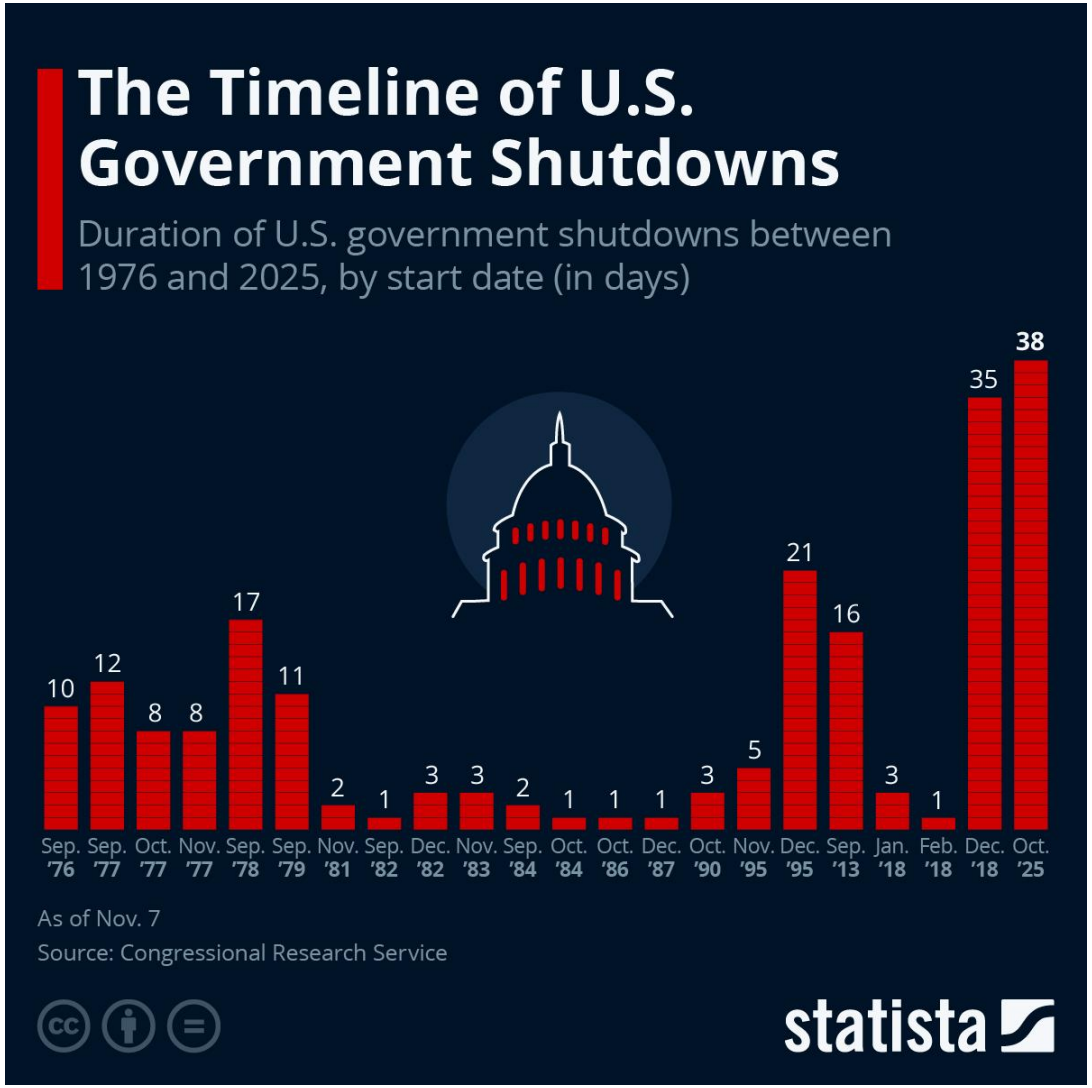


What will the Senate look like?



What should we expect?

- Messaging legislation
- Failed cloture votes
- A little bipartisan legislation
- **A budget battle**





Bipartisan Stuff?

- Permitting reform
- AI regulation + Data Centers

A Few Rs?

- Ukraine Aid
- Iran war limits
- Tariffs
- Minimum wage

Partisan Stuff?

- Cut ICE/BP
- Executive branch reform
- Restore Medicaid
- End tax cuts

Progressive Stuff?

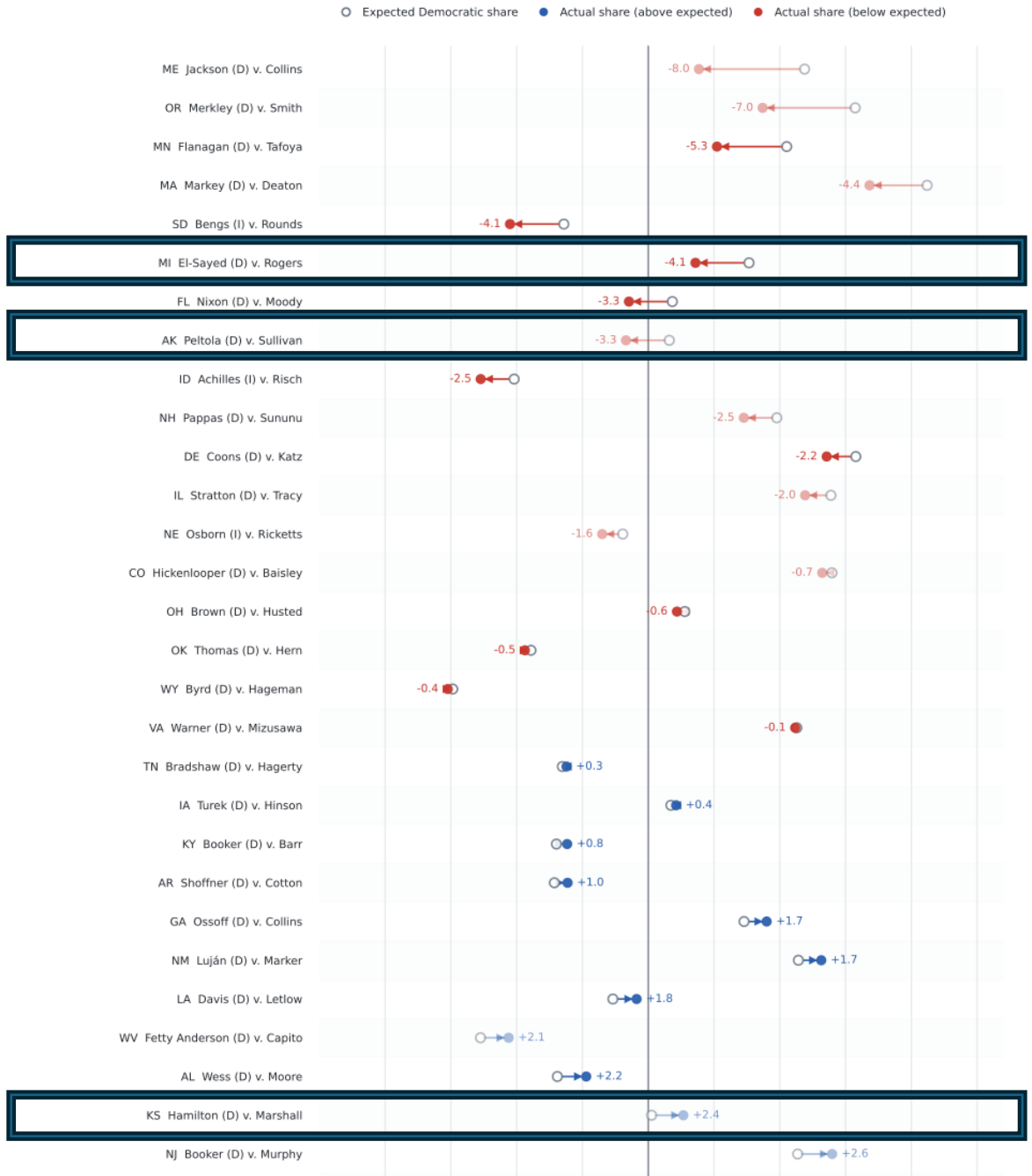
- Medicare-for-all
- Punitive measures towards Israel
- Impeachment

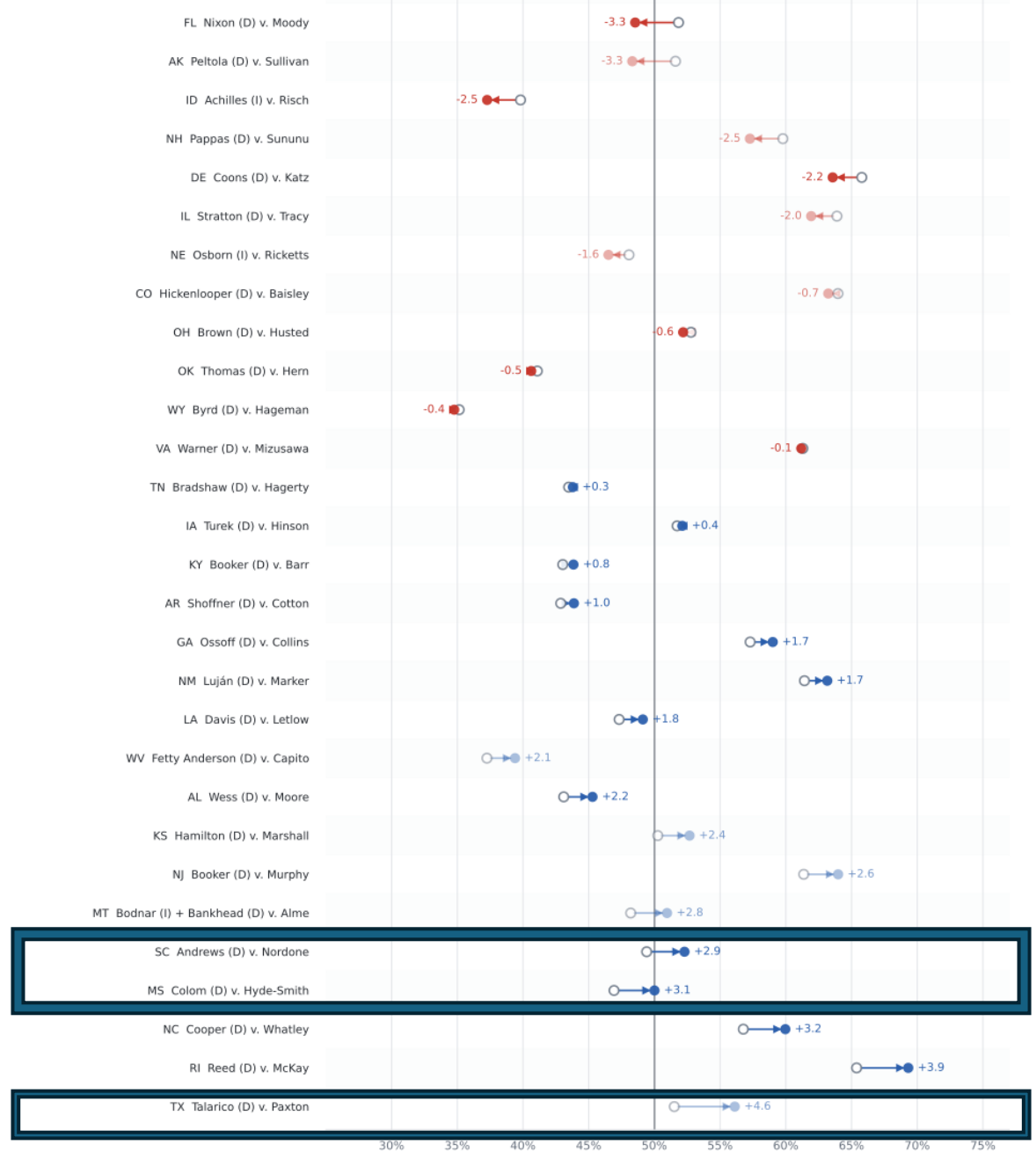
Expected and actual Democratic vote share in Senate races, 2026



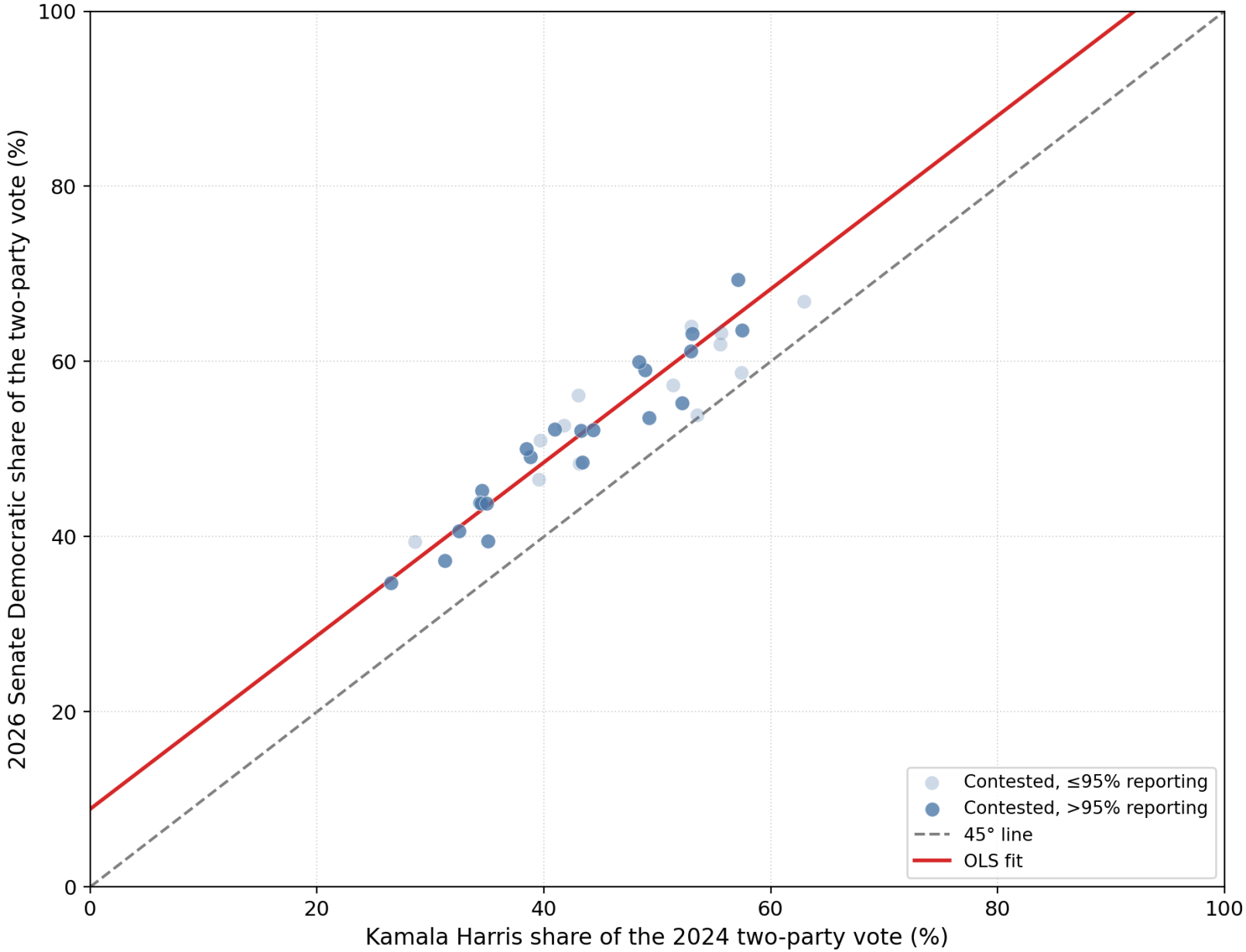
Expected = 8.89 + 0.990 × Harris 2024 two-party vote share (in %). OLS fitted to 22 contested Senate races with >95% reporting.
Labels show actual minus expected (percentage points). Faded markers/arrows: ≤95% reporting, excluded from fit. Preliminary 2026 returns.
Second-place independent vote-getters counted as Democratic (ID, MT, NE, SD); in MT, Democratic votes include both Bodnar and Bankhead.
Data: Cha, DeLuca, Kuriwaki, and Snyder (CAGE, 2024 presidential and 2026 Senate returns).

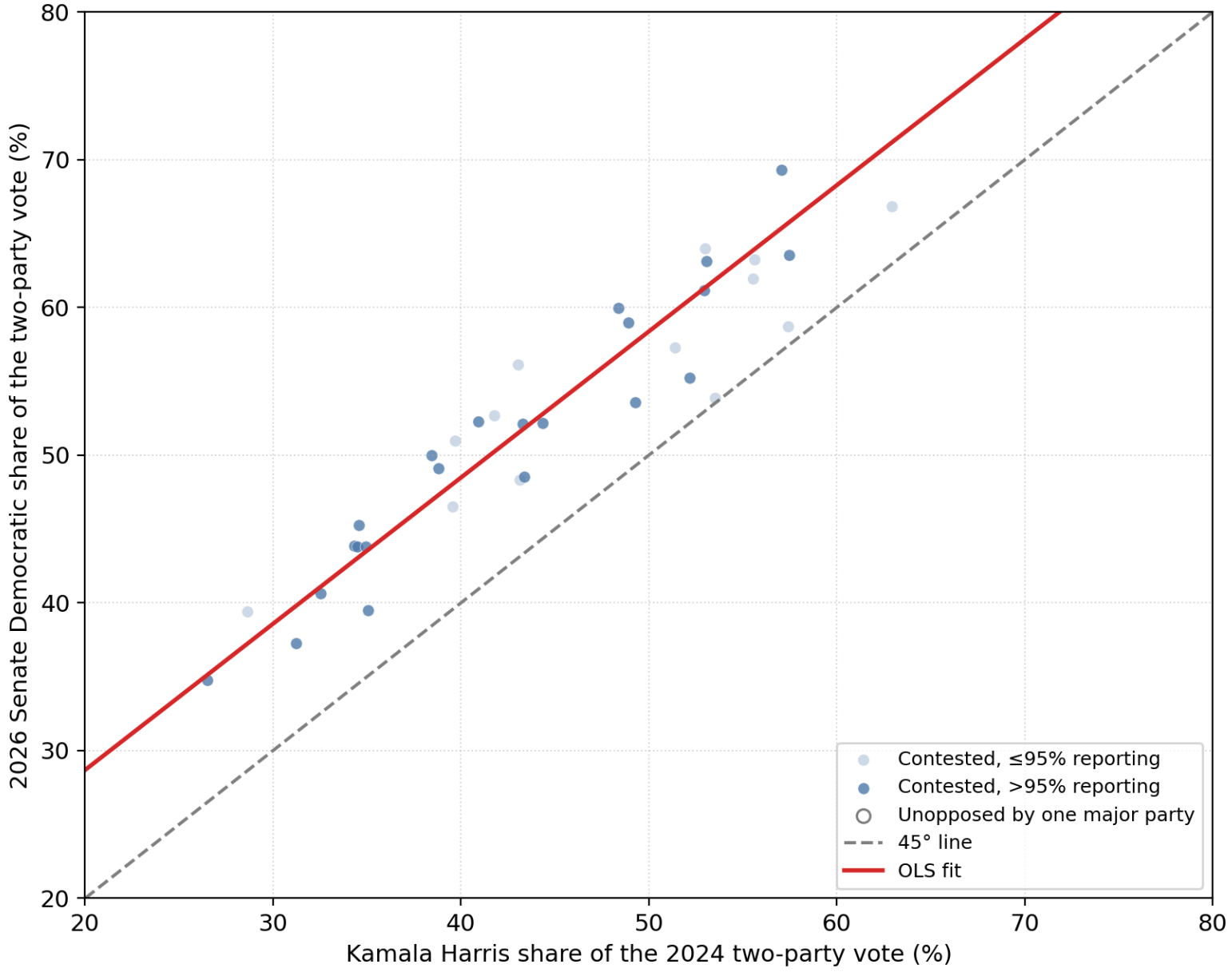
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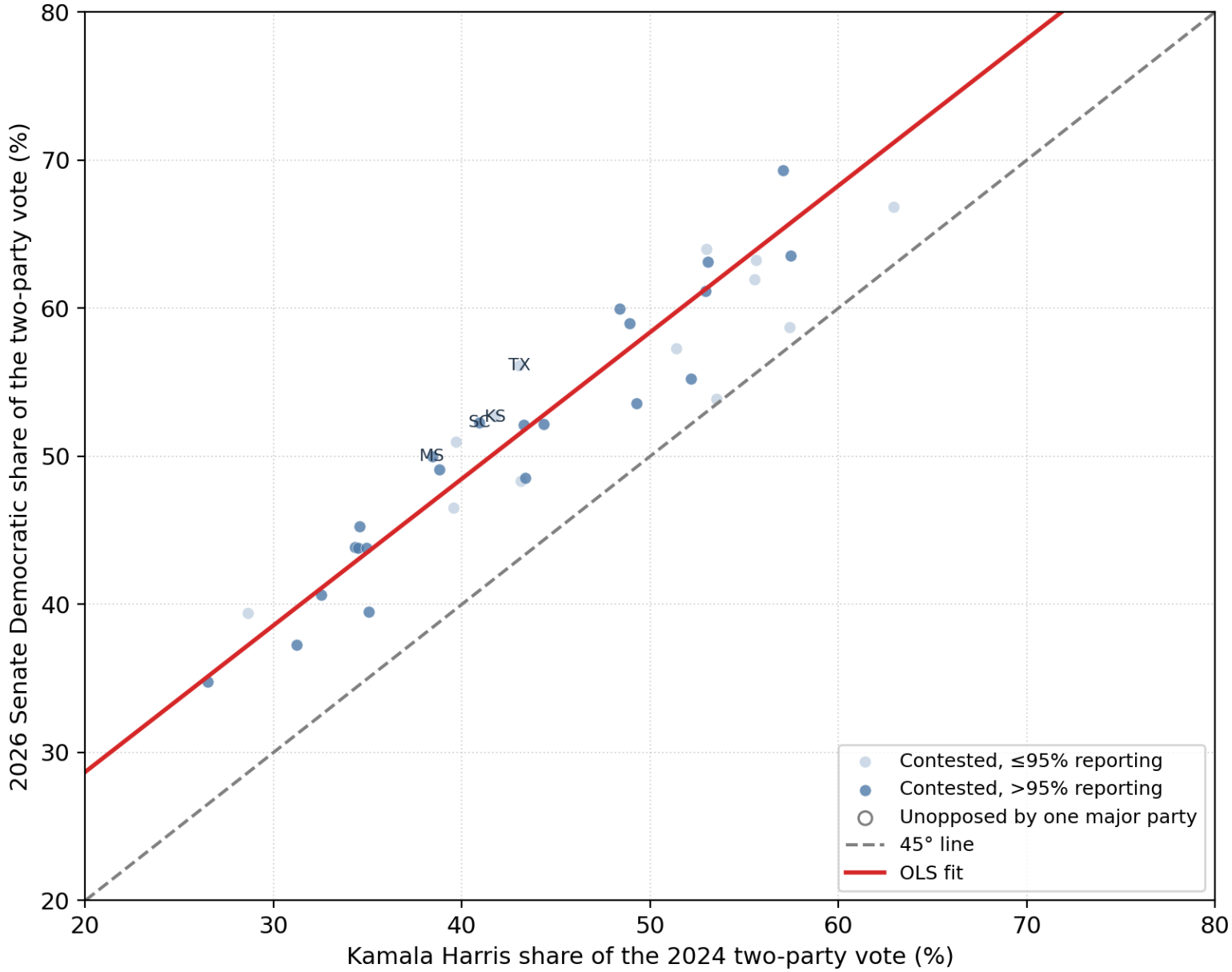




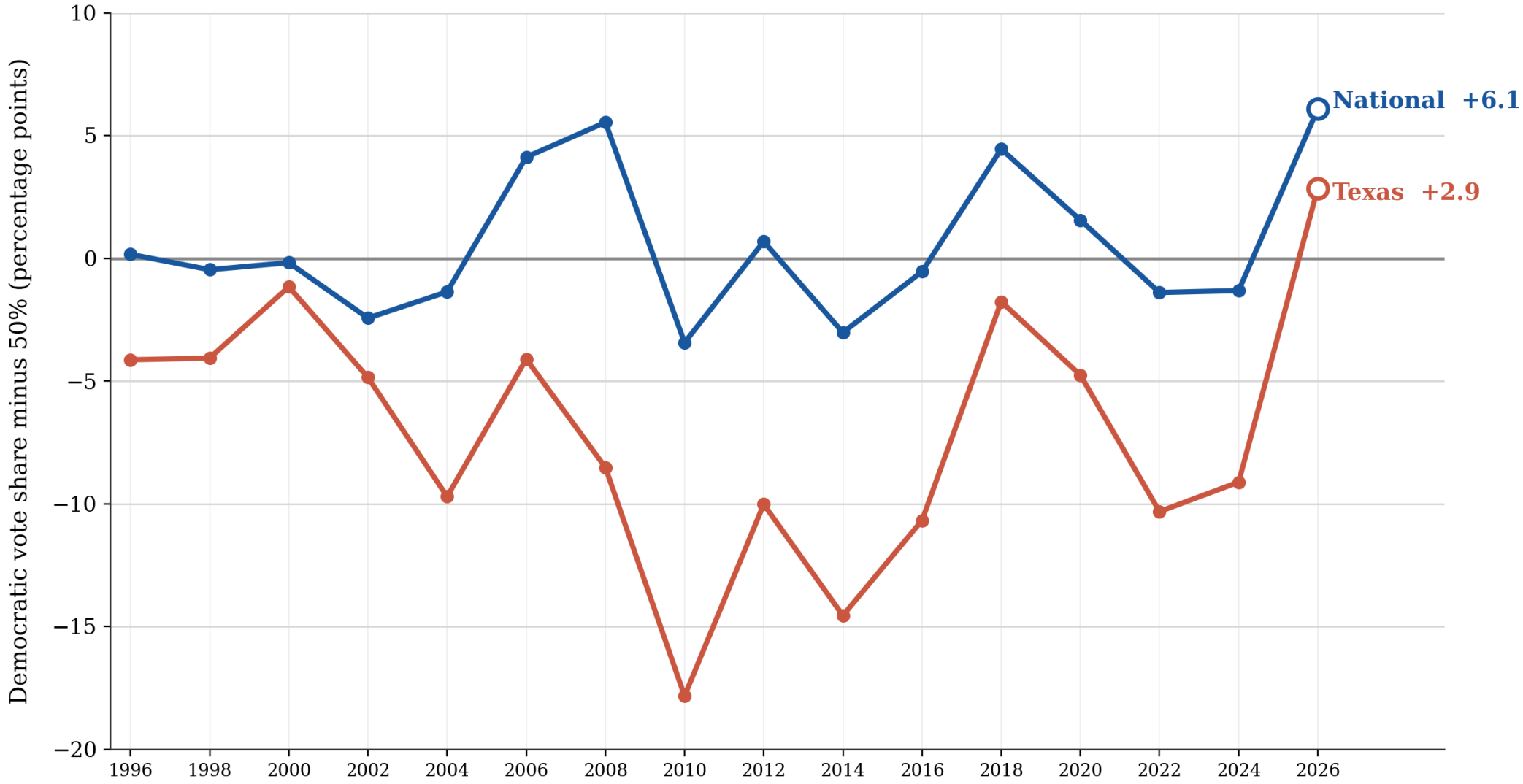
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2026 Senate Democratic share of the two-party vote (%)
Kamala Harris share of the 2024 two-party vote (%)
0
20
40
60
80
100
Contested, ≤95% reporting
Contested, >95% reporting
45° line
OLS fit


2026 Senate Democratic share of the two-party vote (%)
Kamala Harris share of the 2024 two-party vote (%)
20
30
40
50
60
70
80
Contested, ≤95% reporting
Contested, >95% reporting
Unopposed by one major party
45° line
OLS fit


2026 Senate Democratic share of the two-party vote (%)
Kamala Harris share of the 2024 two-party vote (%)
20
30
40
50
60
70
80
TX
KS
MS
Contested, ≤95% reporting
Contested, >95% reporting
Unopposed by one major party
45° line
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Democratic Two-Party Vote in House Elections, 1996–2026



Sources: Official U.S. House/Texas election returns, 1996–2024; 2026 provisional counted returns. Two-party Democratic vote = D/(D+R) − 50%.

Open circles: provisional 2026. Texas 1996 and 2006 include November special-election votes; no runoff double-counting.